



THE OPERATOR SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

The \$3M/Month Ad Playbook

Seven operating decisions for a stronger insurance lead system.

Buying more leads is easy. Knowing which leads you can afford—and building the system to work them—is the real job.

Insurance agents

Agency owners

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Founder, LeadsBakery

Apply the same operating discipline at your scale. Includes a lead economics worksheet, a weekly scorecard, and a 30-day action plan.



[START HERE](#)

Build the system behind the spend.

You can buy an inexpensive lead and still lose money. You can buy a more expensive lead and keep more money. The difference lives between the first click and the placed policy.

This playbook connects seven decisions across that journey. It is not a requirement to spend \$3M—or even \$100K—a month. Use the principles at a budget and workload your business can support.



Finance discipline. Hands-on execution.

I worked in audit and financial modeling at **Ernst & Young and Grant Thornton** before moving into a CFO role. That finance background shapes how I look at acquisition: money in, money out, and what actually stays in the business.

Today I'm CTO of **GOAT Leads** and founder of **LeadsBakery**. My work connects advertising, funnels, lead routing, CRM workflows, and unit economics.

Writing your own business?

Start with your allowable lead cost, contact process, and one source you can measure. A spreadsheet and a disciplined weekly review can be enough to begin.

Running an agency?

Look at economics by source and product, routing by agent, and whether your team can work the volume you plan to buy.

Read it once. Then use it weekly.

Pages 3–9 cover the seven decisions. Page 10 shows the spend receipts behind my experience. Page 11 is your scorecard and action plan. Bring that page to the teardown on page 12.

This is an operating framework, not a promise of profit. Outcomes depend on your product, compensation, lead source, sales process, and execution.



DECISION 01 · ECONOMICS

Run acquisition like a P&L.

The useful question is not “How cheap is this lead?” It is “What can I pay for this lead and still retain the contribution my business needs?”

THE PER-LEAD CEILING

Break-even CPL = lead-to-placed rate × net retained contribution per placed policy – working cost per lead.

CPL = cost per delivered lead. This is a per-lead ceiling, not cost per acquired policy. Choose a buying target below it to leave room for overhead, profit, and uncertainty.

Illustrative completed cohort	Example
Delivered leads → leads with a placed policy	200 → 16
Lead-to-placed rate	$16 \div 200 = 8\%$
Net retained contribution per placed policy	\$400
Working cost per lead	\$2
Break-even CPL	$8\% \times \$400 - \$2 = \$30$
Chosen reserve → target CPL	\$6 per lead → \$24

Hypothetical numbers, not client results or benchmarks. This example counts one placed policy per converted lead. At \$24 CPL: $16 \times \$400 - 200 \times (\$24 + \$2) = \$1,200$ before overhead and tax.

Keep the inputs honest. Net retained contribution accounts for splits, expected chargebacks, and policy-level costs. Working cost covers lead handling. Count expenses once. For multiple policies, multiply the share of leads with a placed policy by average total net policy contribution per converted lead. Use a mature cohort and track cash separately from modeled contribution.

Use your own inputs on the working page (page 11). Keep a separate cash ledger for payments, advances, and reversals.

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Set your ceiling before you change a budget. A bid strategy can help control delivery; it cannot repair bad unit economics.



DECISION 02 · WEEKLY WINNERS

Refresh for a reason.

A winning ad is an asset. Review it each week, but do not restart it just because a calendar says so. Performance can change because of creative fatigue, auction costs, audience mix, tracking, or sales execution.

Read the signal before changing the campaign

What changed?	What to inspect next
Delivery cost rose	Auction costs, reach, frequency, and whether spend moved into a different audience.
Response to the ad fell	Hook, creative relevance, placement, and audience saturation.
Lead cost rose after the click	Message match, page speed, form errors, and tracking changes.
Lead cost held; placed results fell	Lead mix, routing, response times, agent capacity, and cohort maturity.

Make the smallest useful change

If the problem is the hook, test a new hook. If a form broke, repair it. If agents are behind, fix the backlog before buying more. Keep a record of what changed and when.

For an individual agent

Compare your recent cohorts from the same source. Ask whether you worked them consistently before blaming the ad or vendor.

For an agency owner

Look by source, product, and agent. A blended average can hide one strong segment and one leaking segment.

One change worth testing this week

Observed signal → suspected cause → proposed change:

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Keep the current winner as your control. A relaunch is an experiment—not a guaranteed reset of fatigue.



DECISION 03 · TESTING GROUNDS

Buy learning you can use.

A test should answer a business question. “Let’s try more ads” is activity. “Does a clearer qualification message improve placed-policy economics?” is a test you can learn from.

Write the test before you spend

1. **Hypothesis:** what change should affect what outcome?
2. **Comparison:** which current approach is the control?
3. **Spend and capacity:** what can you afford, and who will work the leads?
4. **Decision:** what evidence will make you keep, stop, or revise it?

Protect the budget that supports current production. Separate experimental spend when it makes measurement clearer, while avoiding unnecessary campaign fragmentation. The right structure depends on budget, volume, objective, and the platform’s current options.

Agent-sized application

Use one source, one product, and one change at a time. A vendor trial or a follow-up change can be a better first test than a new ad account.

Agency-sized application

Tag test leads through the CRM. Compare contact, placement, retained contribution, and how long results take to mature.

Your next test

I believe changing ____ will improve ____ because ____:

Control / test spend / owner / review date:

No fixed “50 leads” rule or universal daily budget establishes a winner. Smaller samples are noisy; different products take different time to place. If the evidence is thin, call the result inconclusive.

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Graduate a test when the quality and economics support the decision—not just when the cost per lead looks good.



DECISION 04 · SEGMENTATION

Different products. Different math.

Final expense, mortgage protection, IUL, and other insurance products can attract different buyers and create different operating demands. Give each segment the reporting it needs before deciding how many campaigns or accounts you need.

Separate the decision before separating the account

- **Economics:** product, compensation, placement lag, and retained contribution.
- **Experience:** the consumer's actual intent, ad message, landing page, and form.
- **Operations:** the agent who can serve the lead, routing rules, and available capacity.
- **Reporting:** source and product tags that stay with the record through placement.

Structure follows the business

Separate campaigns, datasets, or accounts only when the business and measurement need it. More accounts create more administration and can divide useful signals. They do not remove business-wide platform obligations.

Use accurate product claims, current platform requirements, and the carrier and contact rules that apply to your work. Do not design around evading a review or hiding the identity of the business.

Map one segment

Product / audience / geography

Contribution target / placement lag

Ad → form → source tag

Routing owner / capacity / fallback

Where placement is recorded

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Create a clean view of segment economics first. Change account structure when that view identifies a real operating need.



DECISION 05 · CREATIVE

Give buyers a reason to respond.

Video and images are formats, not strategies by themselves. The creative needs to earn attention, explain the offer, and set an expectation the next page and agent can honor.

What is the buyer thinking?

Write the question, concern, or decision the consumer is actually facing. Build the hook around that—not around a marketer’s clever line.

What happens after the click?

Make the action clear. The person should understand what they are requesting and what kind of follow-up to expect.

Test the message, then the execution

Variable	A useful comparison
Hook	Two different buyer questions, with the same offer.
Explanation	A straightforward image versus a short video explaining the same request.
Expectation	Clear next-step wording versus wording that leaves follow-up unclear.
Outcome	Contact and placement by creative tag—not clicks alone.

Compare formats when the data supports it

Separate format budgets if you need a controlled comparison and have enough volume. Combining formats may be more practical at smaller budgets. Use the platform’s current tools; do not force a structure just to make a tidy spreadsheet.

Your next creative brief

Buyer concern / honest offer / expected next step:

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Keep a creative when it brings buyers your team can serve at economics you can sustain. “Cheap leads” alone do not settle the decision.



DECISION 06 · FRONT-END MATCH

Keep the promise after the click.

An ad, a landing page, a form, and the first conversation should feel like one experience. When the message changes between those steps, you spend money buying confusion.

Walk your funnel like a consumer

1. **Ad:** what did I believe I was asking for?
2. **Page:** does the product and promise match?
3. **Form:** are the requested fields and follow-up clear?
4. **Confirmation:** do I know what happens next?
5. **Conversation:** does the agent know the request I made?

Localize only what you can stand behind

Use geography, language, and product context when they improve relevance. Do not imply a local office, carrier affiliation, government endorsement, or benefit that is not real. Have fluent reviewers check translated consumer-facing copy.

Check on a phone. Open the real page, read the offer, and test the form and confirmation in a safe test environment. Look for tiny text, slow images, fields hidden by overlays, and a page that sends visitors somewhere unexpected.

One promise, end to end

Step	What the consumer expects
Ad	
Page + form	
First contact	

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Repair the first break in expectation. You do not need a different page for every state unless it improves relevance or operations.



DECISION 07 · SPEED TO LEAD

Every lead needs an owner.

A lead cannot turn into a useful conversation while it sits in a queue nobody owns. Routing, response time, and follow-up discipline are part of acquisition—not work to sort out after you scale.

Define the handoff

- **Delivery:** record creation time and delivery time.
- **Ownership:** assign an agent who can serve the request.
- **First action:** record the first attempt and the first live contact separately.
- **Fallback:** decide who handles an unavailable agent or failed delivery.
- **Next step:** record disposition and the next follow-up date.

Set a response target your team can meet and measure it. Automate routing and reminders where they help, but verify the workflow. An automated message is not a completed human conversation.

Build a follow-up cadence around what the person requested, the product, and valid contact permissions. Honor opt-outs and applicable restrictions. More attempts are not useful if the team has the wrong context or the person no longer wants contact.

For an individual agent

Use a reliable alert, a next-action list, and a clear schedule for working leads. Do not buy volume you cannot work.

For an agency owner

Review time-to-attempt, contact rate, backlog, and placed results by agent. Check the fallback and duplicate rules.

Make the next handoff explicit

New lead owner / first-action target / unavailable-owner fallback:

Unworked-lead report / person reviewing it / review schedule:

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Measure delivery → first attempt → live contact → placed policy. Improve the leaking stage before increasing volume.

\$38M+ in managed ad spend.

Meta Ads Manager

\$30,113,707.30

Had delivery

Search to filter by name, ID or metrics

Jul 15, 2024 - Jul 15, 2026

Plot table

Group breakdowns

Reset column widths

Format

Customize

Account name	Reach	Impressions	Frequency	Amount spent	Attribution setting	Cost per lead	Leads
	14,531,839	145,567,949	10.02	\$8,366,692.00	Multiple attribution settin...	\$17.10	489,170
	16,727,004	115,866,090	6.93	\$5,481,453.00	Multiple attribution settin...	\$34.04	161,052
	13,967,775	93,312,048	6.68	\$4,985,629.00	Multiple attribution settin...	\$33.71	147,904
	15,373,836	77,866,839	5.07	\$2,928,778.71	Multiple attribution settin...	\$18.66	156,932
	8,332,994	43,660,584	5.24	\$2,807,001.13	Multiple attribution settin...	\$36.02	80,695
	9,284,133	42,905,747	4.64	\$2,806,578.69	Multiple attribution settin...	\$32.67	85,914
	7,055,687	61,192,826	8.67	\$2,099,207.27	Multiple attribution settin...	\$43.29	48,490
	2,618,093	9,840,669	3.76	\$417,934.79	Multiple attribution settin...	\$28.85	14,485
	1,149,098	2,016,299	1.75	\$75,383.55	Multiple attribution settin...	\$24.87	3,031
	220,412	586,805	2.66	\$41,552.38	7-day click or 1-day view	\$18.21	2,282
	15,948	22,615	1.42	\$3,496.78	7-day click or 1-day view	\$132.80	21
Total results	45,391,353	592,938,371	13.06	\$30,113,703.30	Multiple attribution setti...	\$25.31	1,389,886
11 of 11 rows displayed	Meta Accounts	Total	Per Meta Account	Total spent	Per Action	Total	

Google Ads

\$8,102,912.50

November 1, 2024–August 15, 2026 · Account and manager details redacted.

Why this matters to your business

At scale, advertising, cash flow, data, routing, and sales execution have to work together. That is the operating perspective I bring to an agent's funnel or an agency's infrastructure.

Combined displayed spend: \$38,216,619.80. The windows overlap and differ by platform. Google conversions and Meta leads are different measures; this page does not add them together as unique people.

View the larger receipts and current work: jeromykovatana.com/results



WORKING PAGE · 30-DAY PLAN

Find the leak. Make one move.

Use one consistent cohort and let placement results mature. Leads delivered this week and policies placed this week may belong to different groups.

My source / product / cohort dates: _____

Delivered leads / spend / cost per lead

First-attempt timing / live contacts

Applications / placed policies

Lead-to-placed rate / retained contribution

Working costs / target CPL

Week 1 · See the system

Calculate the lead ceiling. Map the consumer journey and routing handoff. Mark missing data.

Week 2 · Repair the leak

Fix one high-impact break: message match, form, routing, response, or follow-up.

Suggested sequence—not a promised 30-day result. Some products need a longer observation window.

My biggest unknown or leak:

The first change / owner / completion date:

The metric / cohort / review date that will tell us if it helped:

Bring this page to your [Free Funnel Teardown](#). A blank field is a place to start, not a reason to wait.

Week 3 · Run one test

Write the hypothesis, control, spend, owner, and decision. Keep the rest consistent.

Week 4 · Review the evidence

Keep, revise, or stop. If placement is still maturing, schedule another review before scaling.



WORK WITH JEROMY

Turn the numbers into a decision.

Get a clear view of where your funnel leaks and which change to make first.

FREE FUNNEL TEARDOWN · 30 MINUTES

Bring your numbers. Leave with a first move.

- Your leak stage.
- What the math looks like fixed.
- The one change I'd make first.
- The recording and notes—yours whether we work together or not.

Get your Free Funnel Teardown →

jeromykovatana.com/contact#book

If the teardown isn't useful in the first 10 minutes, we call it there. No pitch.

Two ways to work together

GOAT Leads: the platform, systems, and lead engine. **Work with me directly:** acquisition and operating systems inside your business. Scope follows your bottleneck, economics, and capacity.

Bring what you have

A recent lead cohort, spend, contact and placed-policy counts, retained commissions, and a look at your routing and follow-up. If something is unknown, mark it unknown. That is useful information too.

Explore my work: jeromykovatana.com · Booking alternative: cal.com/jeromyk/funnel-teardown

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